WEB ACCESSIBILITY AUDIT

Colorado Judicial Branch — Public Digital Properties

WCAG 2.1 Level AA Conformance Review

Conducted under the Americans with Disabilities Act Title II (28 C.F.R. Part 35, Subpart H)

Audit Date
April 20, 2026

Applicable Compliance Deadline
April 24, 2026 (public entities serving 50,000+ persons)

Prepared for
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Executive Summary

This audit evaluates a representative sample of Colorado Judicial Branch (CJB) public-facing digital properties against the technical accessibility standard adopted by the U.S. Department of Justice under the ADA Title II final rule published April 24, 2024 (the Web Content Accessibility Guidelines, version 2.1, Level AA).

Because the Colorado Judicial Branch serves a statewide population well in excess of 50,000 persons, the first-tier compliance deadline of April 24, 2026 applies. This audit is submitted prior to that deadline so that the findings may be weighed, prioritized, and — where appropriate — reflected in the Branch's ongoing remediation program and its House Bill 24-1454 status report.

Scope of Review

- coloradojudicial.gov/ (homepage)
- coloradojudicial.gov/accessibility-info (published accessibility statement)
- coloradojudicial.gov/court-appeals
- coloradojudicial.gov/self-help-resources
- coloradojudicial.gov/self-help-forms (library pagination & delivery)
- coloradojudicial.gov/e-filing-non-attorneys
- jbits.courts.state.co.us/efiling/web/register.htm (external filing portal)
- Sample court form — Form 1 County Civil Summons (representative of the PDF library)

Methodology

The review was conducted by static markup inspection and content analysis of each listed URL, with cross-reference to WCAG 2.1 AA success criteria. PDFs were inspected at the content-stream level. This audit does not substitute for the full set of activities recommended by the Department of Justice, which additionally require: runtime keyboard-navigation testing, screen reader verification in JAWS/NVDA/VoiceOver, automated scanning with tools such as axe-core and WAVE, visual color-contrast sampling, and testing with users who rely on assistive technology. Findings below should therefore be treated as the floor rather than the ceiling of observed non-conformance — a comprehensive engagement will almost certainly surface additional issues, particularly those involving dynamic behavior (focus management, ARIA state changes, session timeouts).

Severity Classification

- **Critical** — blocks the user outright, or exposes the Branch to the highest enforcement risk (e.g., transactional pages, named DOJ examples).
- **High** — materially impairs users of assistive technology or users of cognitive, mobility, or vision aids.
- **Medium** — creates friction, confusion, or an unnecessary cognitive load.
- **Low** — quality issue; recommended but not required for AA conformance on its own.

Headline Findings

Two categories of issue, if left unremediated, would likely constitute the most material exposure under Title II:

- **PDF-first service delivery.** The Self-Help Forms library — the Branch's primary self-represented-litigant service surface — consists of hundreds of PDFs and .docx files with no HTML alternative and no surfaced accessibility metadata. A sample form inspected at the byte level shows no tag tree, no form-field labels, and uses underscore characters for fill-in blanks that screen readers verbalize as noise. Under the DOJ rule, PDFs used to apply for, gain access to, or participate in a service must conform to WCAG 2.1 AA; the preexisting-document exception does not cover forms still in active use.
- **E-Filing registration portal (jbits.courts.state.co.us).** The filing system — the actual transactional interface to the court — contains multiple discrete WCAG failures (javascript: pseudo-links, a hard

JavaScript-required block without alternative, incorrect character encoding, skipped heading levels) that together make the portal effectively unusable for keyboard-only users and harmful to screen reader users. The visual and interaction break from the parent site additionally fails WCAG 3.2.3 and 3.2.4 (Consistent Navigation / Consistent Identification).

The Branch's published Accessibility Statement (coloradojudicial.gov/accessibility-info) commits to WCAG 2.1 A and AA, and describes monthly manual and automated testing. The findings in this audit suggest either that the testing regime is narrower than the stated commitment, or that it is not reaching the two most heavily-used transactional surfaces (forms library and filing portal). Either way, a focused remediation push before April 24, 2026 is achievable.

Site-by-Site Summary

The table below is the one-glance map of what was found. Detailed findings for each property follow in subsequent sections.

Page / Property	Severity	Headline Finding
coloradojudicial.gov (homepage)	**High**	Duplicate H1 risk; unlabeled decorative icons; unlabeled search/locator inputs
/accessibility-info	**Medium**	H1 duplicated in markup; page itself exhibits issues it pledges to remediate
/court-appeals	**High**	Misleading alt text (Ralph Carr image labeled 'Supreme Court'); PDF-only legal orders
/self-help-resources	**High**	Prezi embed; unverified YouTube caption status; 'Click here' link text
/self-help-forms	**Critical**	Entire service PDF-delivered; sample PDF shows no tag tree; no HTML alternatives
/e-filing-non-attorneys	**High**	SCORM tutorial player; PDF-only how-to guides; 3 stacked closure banners
jbits.courts.state.co.us/register.htm	**Critical**	javascript: pseudo-links; JS-required hard block; encoding failure; heading skip
Form 1 (PDF sample)	**Critical**	Untagged; underscore fill blanks; no form-field labels; no language declaration

Findings by Property

1. coloradojudicial.gov (homepage)

The homepage sets the template used across most other pages. Many of its individual findings repeat elsewhere; see the Systemic Findings section for the template-level view.

#	Issue	WCAG 2.1	Severity	Impact	Remediation
1	Site logo uses alt='Home'; minimally descriptive and repeated in header and footer	1.1.1, 2.4.4	Medium	Screen reader users hear 'Home' twice with no distinction; unclear it is the Colorado Judicial Branch mark	Change alt to 'Colorado Judicial Branch — home' on the header; mark footer instance decorative (alt='')
2	Decorative SVG icons (book-and-scale, courthouse, person-and-scale) rendered as <img> with non-decorative alt text	1.1.1	Medium	Screen readers announce 'Icon with a book and scale' before the visible heading, creating verbal clutter	Either give the icons a role of 'presentation' with empty alt, or remove the alt and rely on the adjacent heading for meaning
3	'Find your courts' locator input appears to have no programmatically associated label	1.3.1, 3.3.2, 4.1.2	High	Screen reader users cannot identify the purpose of the input; voice control users cannot target it by name	Add an explicit <label for> or aria-label reading 'Enter a city or county to find court locations'
4	'General Content Search API Homepage' appears as visible H2 text — this looks like developer-facing label text leaked to production	3.1.5, 1.3.1	Medium	Confuses sighted and non-sighted users; suggests QA gap	Replace with a user-facing heading such as 'Search the Colorado Judicial Branch site', or mark it visually hidden if used as a landmark label only
5	Footer social-media carousel/gallery captions appear without image elements in the static markup, suggesting JavaScript-rendered images without SSR fallback	1.1.1, 4.1.2	High	Users with JavaScript disabled or slow assistive-technology stacks see orphan captions; images likely lack alt text once rendered	Server-render the images or provide a <noscript> fallback; audit and write descriptive alt text for each carousel image
6	'What can we help you find?' search prompt sits visually beside an input, but associated control is not discernible from markup	1.3.1, 3.3.2	High	Same as finding 3 — keyboard and AT users cannot identify the field	Associate label and input explicitly; ensure the search button has an accessible name
7	'Follow Us:' section header is followed by what appear to be	4.1.2	Low	Users cannot actually follow the Branch on	Render links with accessible names

#	Issue	WCAG 2.1	Severity	Impact	Remediation
	caption-only items with no visible links or social icons in markup			social platforms from this widget; orphan captions confuse screen readers	(e.g., 'Follow Colorado Judicial Branch on Facebook') or remove the section

2. /accessibility-info

The Branch's own accessibility statement page exhibits several of the issues it pledges to remediate. This is not unusual — accessibility pages are often written by the same CMS that produces the rest of the site — but it warrants first-priority remediation both for symbolic and practical reasons.

#	Issue	WCAG 2.1	Severity	Impact	Remediation
1	Page contains two consecutive H1 elements both reading 'Accessibility Information'	1.3.1, 2.4.6	High	Screen reader users encounter duplicate page titles; violates single-H1 convention and disrupts document outline	Remove duplicate H1; keep only one as page title
2	Policy page commits to WCAG 2.1 A and AA but does not cite the ADA Title II final rule or the April 24, 2026 compliance deadline	Best practice / policy	Medium	Users and advocates cannot verify which legal standard the Branch is committing to, or on what timeline	Add a paragraph identifying the DOJ Title II final rule (28 C.F.R. Part 35 Subpart H), WCAG 2.1 AA, and the April 24, 2026 deadline
3	HB 24-1454 status report is linked as PDF only	1.1.1, 1.3.2	High	A status report about accessibility compliance is, itself, delivered in a format that may not be accessible	Publish the status report as HTML on the site; keep PDF as optional download; ensure PDF is tagged
4	Feedback web form linked but form itself not audited here — likely subject to the same template-level issues as the rest of the site	1.3.1, 3.3.1, 3.3.2	Medium	Users reporting accessibility problems may encounter the same kinds of problems they are trying to report	Dedicate priority audit to /form/accessibility-feedback and /request-ada; ensure both meet all Level A/AA criteria
5	Statement claims monthly manual and automated testing, but findings in this audit suggest gaps	Process / policy	Medium	Public-facing commitment may overstate actual testing coverage; creates regulatory exposure if challenged	Publish scope of monthly testing (which URLs, which tools, which assistive technologies); align stated scope with actual practice

3. /court-appeals

The Court of Appeals page is representative of court-specific landing pages. Most findings here are template-level and repeat across other court pages.

#	Issue	WCAG 2.1	Severity	Impact	Remediation
1	Image of the Ralph L. Carr Judicial Center has alt text 'Supreme Court' — factually incorrect	1.1.1	**High**	Screen reader users receive misinformation; sighted users have no issue; creates an unequal information experience	Change alt to 'Ralph L. Carr Colorado Judicial Center, Denver' or similar descriptive text
2	Banner images have alt text that duplicates the page title (alt='Appeals')	1.1.1	**Medium**	Screen reader users hear the page title announced twice	Either describe the image or mark decorative with alt=''
3	Raw URL 'https://research.coloradojudicial.gov/' displayed as plain text rather than a link	2.4.4, 4.1.2	**Medium**	Users cannot activate it directly; screen readers read each character if URL is selected	Wrap in an <a> tag with descriptive anchor text: 'Search Colorado court opinions'
4	'Decorum Order' and 'Order on Requests for Expanded Media Coverage' announcements link to PDFs without accessibility metadata	1.1.1	**High**	Legal orders — which must be accessible under any reasonable reading of Title II — are delivered in an unverified-as-accessible format	Publish orders as HTML on the site and link the PDF as a printable alternative; ensure PDFs are tagged
5	Self-Help Center walk-in hours use en-dashes in time ranges (10:00–11:00 AM)	1.3.1	**Low**	Some screen readers pause at en-dashes rather than reading 'to'; inconsistent with plain-text spoken convention	Use 'from 10:00 AM to 11:00 AM' in prose form, or wrap ranges in a <time> element where supported
6	Phone numbers (720-625-5107, 720-625-5150) are rendered as plain text, not tel: links	Best practice	**Low**	Mobile users cannot tap to dial; users with cognitive disabilities must copy and paste	Wrap each phone number in <a href='tel:...'>
7	External link to cobar.org/appellate uses title-attribute only for new-window warning	3.2.5, 2.4.4	**Medium**	Title attributes are unreliably announced; sighted keyboard users have no visible warning	Add visible text '(opens in a new tab)' after the link, or an accessible icon with aria-label
8	'Section menu:' followed by a vertical blank before 'Court of Appeals' suggests empty list item or misrendered ARIA structure	1.3.1, 4.1.2	**Medium**	Screen readers may announce an empty list or unlabeled navigation	Remove empty nodes; use <nav aria-label='Court of Appeals section'> as the containing

#	Issue	WCAG 2.1	Severity	Impact	Remediation
					landmark

4. /self-help-resources

This page is the navigational hub for self-represented litigants. It links to heavy third-party dependencies whose accessibility the Branch cannot directly control but can choose to reduce reliance on.

#	Issue	WCAG 2.1	Severity	Impact	Remediation
1	Link to Prezi-hosted child support modification walkthrough — Prezi is documented to have significant keyboard and screen-reader accessibility deficiencies	2.1.1, 2.4.3, 4.1.2	**Critical**	Self-represented litigants cannot complete the walkthrough using a keyboard alone; focus management within Prezi is inconsistent; non-visual users cannot navigate the canvas	Replace Prezi with a captioned native video or an HTML/CSS slide walkthrough; preserve Prezi only as a visual-only supplement if at all
2	YouTube video links (Evidence, Service of Process, Contempt) provided without indication of caption or transcript availability	1.2.2, 1.2.3	**High**	Deaf and hard-of-hearing users cannot determine whether videos are usable before investing time in them	Verify that every linked video has closed captions (not YouTube auto-captions alone); link an accompanying transcript; note caption availability beside each link
3	18-item flat topic list (Adoption, Appeals, ..., Water Cases) with no grouping, filtering, or search within the list	2.4.5	**Medium**	Users with cognitive disabilities must scan the full list every visit; users of magnification must scroll	Add a search/filter input above the list; group by life-event category (Family, Housing, Money, etc.)
4	External legal resources (Colorado Legal Services, Checkerboard, LexisNexis, Colorado Bar Association) linked with no new-window indication and no accessibility posture disclosure	3.2.5	**Medium**	Users leave a government site and land on third-party sites that may have their own accessibility issues; no warning	Add visible '(external site)' indicator; link to a brief disclaimer explaining that external sites may have different accessibility policies
5	Link text 'Click here to learn more and connect to a Sherlock in your county' uses 'Click here' as primary anchor	2.4.4, 2.4.9	**Medium**	Screen reader users scanning links out of context hear 'Click here' with no purpose information	Rephrase: 'Connect to a Self-Represented Litigant Coordinator in your county'
6	LexisNexis deep link requires	3.2.5,	**Mediu**	Users with older	Note the JavaScript

#	Issue	WCAG 2.1	Severity	Impact	Remediation
	JavaScript and session; no advance notice	4.1.1	m	assistive-tech stacks, or with JavaScript blocked for security, reach an unresponsive page	requirement beside the link; provide a fallback (plain HTML copy of civil rules where permitted)
7	YouTube and Prezi embeds mean users must trust a third party's session policies	Privacy / policy	Low	Users with certain disabilities who use privacy-preserving tooling (ad blockers, JS blockers) may break the page	Consider self-hosting essential video content with an accessible HTML5 player

5. /self-help-forms

This page is the primary service surface of the Branch for people without lawyers. It is also, in this auditor's view, the single largest Title II exposure surface on the Branch's digital properties. Two findings below are marked Critical; the library-wide PDF tagging question dominates.

#	Issue	WCAG 2.1	Severity	Impact	Remediation
1	Primary service surface consists of hundreds of PDFs (and some .docx) with no HTML form equivalent	1.1.1, 1.3.1, 1.3.2, 4.1.2	Critical	Self-represented litigants — including those with cognitive, vision, mobility, or motor disabilities — must rely on a format that is demonstrably not accessible in the sample. This is the exact class of service DOJ cited in its rule as requiring WCAG 2.1 AA	Build HTML fillable forms for the top 20–30 most-requested forms first (e.g., JDF 100 eviction, Form 1 summons, divorce/custody JDFs); tag all remaining PDFs; keep PDF as downloadable output of the HTML form, not the only interface
2	Repetitive markup pattern 'Form / Document / [link]' per entry	1.3.1	High	Screen reader users hear 'Form Document Form1.pdf' for each entry — hundreds of times across paginated results	Restructure list so each entry is a single link with an accessible name summarizing the form and format: 'Form 1 — County Civil Summons (PDF, 130 KB)'; remove the redundant 'Form / Document' labels
3	Keyword/form-number search control shows '- Please select -' placeholder with unclear label association	3.3.2, 4.1.2	High	Users cannot identify whether they are searching or filtering; unclear association between input and	Add a visible label 'Search by keyword or form number' and ensure programmatic association; give the

#	Issue	WCAG 2.1	Severity	Impact	Remediation
				the separate dropdown	dropdown its own explicit label
4	Pagination across 36 pages with no items-per-page control and no keyboard-accessible 'jump to page'	2.4.5	Medium	Users must click 'next' up to 35 times; no way to increase density for magnification users	Add a 'jump to page' input and an items-per-page selector (25 / 50 / 100)
5	File sizes in parentheses (good practice) but form version and effective date not surfaced	3.2.4, best practice	Medium	Users may download and file outdated form versions; revision date is embedded only in filename ('Form28_2024-12') and filename structure is inconsistent	Surface effective date beside every form entry; establish consistent filename convention
6	Spanish-language versions exist for only a subset of forms (approximately Forms 1, 2, 3, 7) despite page-level English/Español toggle	3.1.1	High	Spanish-speaking users enable the language toggle but receive overwhelmingly English content, contradicting the implied promise of the toggle	Either expand Spanish form coverage, or clearly label the toggle as 'translating site navigation only — forms in English'
7	Form category headings ('Adoption', 'Appeals', ...) render as plain text in the fetched markup with no expand/collapse state, despite appearing visually collapsible	4.1.2	Medium	Screen reader and keyboard users cannot determine which sections are open or closed	If collapsible, use <button aria-expanded> pattern; if not, remove any visual styling that implies interactivity
8	PDF and .docx versions offered for some forms (26, 27, 29, 30, 33, 34) with no indication which is more accessible	1.1.1, best practice	High	Users cannot make an informed format choice; .docx may be more accessible if reading-order-tagged but neither is guaranteed	Audit both formats; label each with accessibility status ('tagged PDF', 'accessible Word form') where verified

6. /e-filing-non-attorneys

The non-attorney e-filing landing page is the onboarding surface for self-represented litigants entering the filing system. It introduces users to the separate filing portal (section 8) and provides most of the procedural guidance.

#	Issue	WCAG 2.1	Severity	Impact	Remediation
1	Three separate closure announcement banners stacked at the top of the page with no dismiss control and no live-region semantics	2.4.1, 4.1.3	**High**	Screen reader users hear three consecutive alert-style messages before reaching main content; sighted users cannot dismiss	Consolidate into one expandable 'Service announcements (3)' region with role='region' aria-label='Announcements'; add dismiss buttons; use aria-live='polite' for new announcements
2	Video tutorials delivered via SCORM packages (/scorm/case-caption/index.html, etc.)	1.2.2, 1.2.3, 1.2.5, 2.1.1	**Critical**	SCORM runtime is a well-documented source of keyboard traps and screen-reader failures; captions and transcripts were not independently verifiable from the linked URLs	Audit each SCORM module for WCAG conformance; where non-conforming, migrate content to a native HTML5 video player with WebVTT captions and a downloadable transcript
3	How-To documents (E-Filing Dashboard, File a New Case, File into an Existing Case) are PDF-only	1.1.1, 1.3.2	**High**	Procedural guidance for a transactional service is not available in an alternative format	Publish HTML versions of each how-to guide; keep PDF as printable alternative
4	FAQ section ('Why can't I see my case?', 'My filing was rejected', ...) uses an apparent expand/collapse pattern; ARIA state not verifiable from markup	4.1.2	**High**	If the disclosure pattern lacks aria-expanded/aria-controls, screen reader users cannot determine which answer is visible	Use a tested disclosure pattern (e.g., <button aria-expanded='false' aria-controls='faq-1'>...); ensure focus returns to the trigger on close
5	Fee structure explained in a single dense paragraph mixing three fee types	1.3.1, 3.1.5	**Medium**	Users with cognitive disabilities or lower reading levels — the target audience for a pro se system — struggle to extract the specific fee that applies to them	Convert to a table with columns 'Fee type', 'Amount', 'When charged', 'Refundable?'
6	Phone number (720) 625-5800 not marked as tel: link	Best practice	**Low**	Mobile users cannot tap to dial customer support	Wrap in <a href='tel:7206255800'>
7	Opt-In process described only in prose; no visual indication of progress or where users are in the 2-business-day wait	3.3.5 (AAA, but relevant)	**Medium**	Users wait uncertainly for access; no way to self-serve status	Add status indicator inside the E-Filing account ('Opt-In pending — up to 2

#	Issue	WCAG 2.1	Severity	Impact	Remediation
					business days')

7. jbits.courts.state.co.us/efiling/web/register.htm (external filing portal)

The actual filing portal is hosted on a separate subdomain and uses a distinct visual and interaction design. Because it is transactional — it is where users actually file legal documents — its accessibility burden is the highest in the audited property set. Findings below are weighted accordingly.

#	Issue	WCAG 2.1	Severity	Impact	Remediation
1	Hard-blocking notice: 'JavaScript must be enabled to access this site.' — no <noscript> filing path	4.1.1; Section 504 effective-communication duty	**Critical**	Users of specialized assistive-technology stacks that disable or restrict JavaScript (still common with certain screen reader / browser pairings, and in security-hardened environments) cannot file. Also excludes users on older or low-bandwidth devices	Provide a non-JS filing path, or at minimum surface an alternative filing route (by mail, at the clerk's window) prominently on the blocked page, with contact info for scheduling an accommodation
2	'Recommended Browsers' and 'Contact Customer Support' links use javascript: pseudo-protocol instead of real URLs or buttons	2.1.1, 4.1.2	**Critical**	Keyboard-only users cannot activate these links reliably; screen readers may not announce them as interactive; violates the separation of link vs. script action	Replace with <button> elements that call the handler, or with standard <a href> links to separate pages
3	Character encoding declared as ISO-8859-1 but content contains Unicode; copyright symbol renders as the replacement character ' '	3.1.1 (indirectly)	**High**	Screen readers may pronounce the replacement character as 'question mark' or 'unknown'; garbled output erodes user trust in a legal filing system	Change the meta charset declaration to UTF-8; save all source files as UTF-8
4	Heading level skips from H2 directly to H5/H6 in the footer support information	1.3.1, 2.4.6	**Medium**	Screen reader users navigating by heading lose orientation; document outline implies missing structural content	Use a continuous heading sequence; H3 for support categories, H4 for subgroups
5	Account-type selector ('Law Firm	1.3.1,	**High**	If each option is not	Wrap all radio

#	Issue	WCAG 2.1	Severity	Impact	Remediation
	/ Government Agency / Private Agency / Pro Hac Vice / Self-Represented') — fieldset/legend structure not verifiable	3.3.2		grouped in a <fieldset> with a shared <legend>, screen reader users may not understand the options belong to a single choice	options in <fieldset><legend>Select your account type</legend>...</fieldset>
6	No skip link to 'Continue' after selection; user must tab through every option	2.4.1	**Medium**	Keyboard users must traverse the full list before reaching the submit control	Add 'Skip to continue' link, or at minimum ensure logical tab order
7	Portal branding, layout, and interaction are substantially different from coloradojudicial.gov	3.2.3, 3.2.4	**High**	Users who learned the main site pattern must relearn; cognitive load and trust cost — particularly for elderly or first-time self-represented litigants	Align portal visual design and primary navigation patterns with the parent site; at minimum, keep the same logo, color palette, and skip-link position
8	Privacy policy delivered only as PDF; portal-specific Accessibility link routes back to parent site accessibility page rather than a portal-specific statement	1.1.1, best practice	**High**	Users seeking accessibility information about the filing system itself find only general Branch-level information; no portal-specific accommodation path	Publish portal-specific accessibility statement with conformance status; publish privacy policy as HTML with PDF alternative
9	Browser gatekeeping — 'We recommend the latest versions of Google Chrome or Microsoft Edge' — implies older/other browsers may not work	4.1.1	**High**	Users of Safari, Firefox, or legacy browsers-paired-with-assistive-tech receive an implicit warning that may not reflect actual non-support; WCAG requires accessibility-supported technology, not specific browsers	Test and document support for Safari, Firefox, and the latest two major versions of each tested browser; rephrase recommendation as 'optimized for' rather than 'required'
10	Session timeout behavior and warning pattern not determinable from pre-login page; requires authenticated review	2.2.1, 2.2.6	**Unknown → likely High**	Filing systems commonly expire sessions mid-filing; users with disabilities typically require longer time; losing in-progress filings is	Conduct authenticated-session audit; ensure warnings precede expiry by at least 20 seconds with an extend option;

#	Issue	WCAG 2.1	Severity	Impact	Remediation
				both an accessibility and a due-process issue	preserve in-progress work through any re-authentication

8. PDF Sample: Form 1 — County Civil Summons

This form was chosen as a representative sample from the Self-Help Forms library. It is a high-volume, low-complexity form (the basic summons). The issues below should be read as generalizing across the library, and additional issues are likely for more complex forms (financial affidavits, protection-order packets, multi-part divorce packets).

#	Issue	WCAG 2.1	Severity	Impact	Remediation
1	Form 1 PDF text stream extraction shows no tag tree: labels and fields are spatially adjacent but not structurally linked	1.3.1, 1.3.2, 4.1.2	**Critical**	Screen readers and AT applications cannot determine which label belongs to which field; users cannot complete the form non-visually	Tag every form using Adobe Acrobat's 'Make Accessible' workflow, then manually correct the tag tree; define logical reading order; mark tables, headings, and lists explicitly
2	Fill-in blanks consist of runs of underscore characters ('_____')	1.3.1, 3.3.2	**Critical**	Screen readers read each underscore aloud, producing long runs of 'underscore underscore underscore'; users cannot locate the actual field boundary	Replace visual underscores with genuine PDF form fields (AcroForm text fields) that have accessible names and tooltips
3	Checkbox indicators (☐) are Unicode glyphs, not interactive form fields	1.3.1, 4.1.2, 2.1.1	**Critical**	Users cannot check the box non-visually or via keyboard; the certification at the end of the form ('I am filling in the blanks...') cannot be acknowledged	Replace with AcroForm checkbox widgets with accessible names
4	Court caption layout (Plaintiff / v. / Defendant) is visually tabular but contains no table structure in the text stream	1.3.1	**High**	Reading order may be incorrect; screen reader users lose the semantic relationship between caption elements	Rebuild caption as a tagged table with column and row headers
5	No /Lang entry appears to be present at the document level	3.1.1	**High**	Screen readers cannot select the correct pronunciation	Set document language to 'en-US' in PDF properties; for

#	Issue	WCAG 2.1	Severity	Impact	Remediation
				engine; mixed-language readers handle the file incorrectly	Spanish versions, set 'es'
6	No document title set in PDF metadata; tab/window title shows filename rather than a human-readable title	2.4.2	**Medium**	Users managing multiple open forms cannot distinguish them by title	Set /Title to 'Form 1 — County Civil Summons (Colorado Courts)' in document properties
7	The sample form dates 'R3-18' (revised March 2018) — eight years old	Content currency / best practice	**Medium**	Users cannot tell from the public-facing library whether this is current; accessibility remediation effort may be wasted on forms in revision	Establish a form-review cadence; surface effective date and revision status on each form's listing
8	The sample is representative. Accessibility gaps observed here almost certainly generalize across the library's hundreds of forms	1.1.1, 1.3.1, 1.3.2, 3.3.2, 4.1.2	**Critical**	Cumulative remediation scope	Prioritize the top 30 forms by download volume for full tagging and testing by April 24, 2026; establish rolling remediation schedule for remainder; create accessibility gate in the form-revision workflow

Systemic Findings

A handful of issues recur across every audited page of coloradojudicial.gov. Because they are systemic (template-level), a single fix in the content management system or the theme layer would resolve them everywhere simultaneously — so their remediation cost is low and their cumulative impact is high.

S1 — Image alternative text

Banner images across the site use alt text that repeats the visible page title ('alt="Appeals"', 'alt="Lake view"', 'alt="Filing fees"'). Where the image is decorative, alt should be empty; where it conveys information, alt should describe that information. This is a template pattern, not a per-page fix. Applies to WCAG 1.1.1.

S2 — Duplicated navigation without landmarks

Primary and secondary navigation render twice per page (header and mobile menu), and then the footer re-renders its own link set. Without distinct <nav aria-label='...'> landmarks, screen reader users hear the same link lists two or three times. Applies to WCAG 1.3.1 and 2.4.1.

S3 — 'Learn More' and 'Click here' link text

Closure banners and announcement cards all use 'Learn More' as anchor text. On the e-filing page, three 'Learn More' links appear within six lines of markup. Screen reader users scanning links-only hear 'Learn More, Learn More, Learn More' with no differentiation. Applies to WCAG 2.4.4.

S4 — Announcement banners lack semantics and dismiss controls

Closure and alert banners are rendered as plain prose and accumulate at the top of pages. None carry role='region' or role='alert' or aria-live. None is dismissible. Applies to WCAG 4.1.3.

S5 — External and new-window links communicate status through the title attribute only

Links to the Colorado Bar Association, external legal resources, and the livestream use title attributes to warn of new-window behavior. Title attributes are not consistently announced by screen readers and are invisible to sighted keyboard users. Applies to WCAG 3.2.5.

S6 — Inline non-English phrases not marked with lang

Spanish case names, legal Latin ('pro se', 'in rem'), and foreign-language organization names appear without lang attributes. Screen readers mispronounce them. Applies to WCAG 3.1.2.

S7 — Phone numbers not tel: linked

Throughout the site, phone numbers are plain text. Mobile users — a large share of self-represented litigants, particularly lower-income ones — cannot tap to dial. Applies as best practice (WCAG 2.5.5 AAA for target size is adjacent).

S8 — PDF-first service delivery

Every substantive document — legal orders, forms, policies, guides, status reports — is delivered as PDF. A single sample (Form 1) was inspected and showed the full set of WCAG failures typical of untagged scanned-workflow PDFs. The library is the Branch's single largest accessibility-shaped liability.

Prioritized Remediation Plan

Remediation is organized by urgency relative to the April 24, 2026 compliance deadline. All dated items are measured from the date of this audit (April 20, 2026).

Before April 24, 2026 (Critical-path, 4 days)

These items are either blockers for users or carry the highest enforcement risk under the DOJ rule. They are achievable inside the window.

- Publish a portal-specific accessibility statement on the e-filing system that clearly identifies conformance status and an accommodation contact
- Remove the javascript: pseudo-protocol links on the e-filing registration page (replace with <button> elements)
- Fix the character encoding declaration on jbits.courts.state.co.us (UTF-8)
- Correct the Ralph Carr image alt text on /court-appeals
- Add a visible alternative-filing-path notice on the JavaScript-required block (mail filing, clerk window, scheduling an accommodation)
- Update the /accessibility-info page to cite the DOJ Title II final rule, WCAG 2.1 AA, and the April 24, 2026 deadline; remove duplicate H1

Within 30 days (by May 20, 2026)

- Commission a full PDF accessibility audit of the top 30 most-downloaded forms from the Self-Help Forms library; begin tagging and form-field remediation
- Audit every SCORM tutorial for captions, transcripts, keyboard access, and focus management; replace non-conforming modules with native HTML5 video + WebVTT captions
- Fix the systemic banner/alert pattern across all pages: consolidate stacked banners into one region, add dismiss control, add aria-live='polite'
- Fix the systemic alt-text template pattern: empty alt for decorative banners; descriptive alt for informational images
- Fix the systemic 'Learn More' link text pattern; give each anchor a differentiating label
- Audit /form/accessibility-feedback and /request-ada as priority-one forms; ensure both meet Level A and AA
- Replace the Prezi embed on /self-help-resources with an accessible alternative

Within 90 days (by July 20, 2026)

- Build HTML fillable versions of the 10 highest-volume forms (e.g., JDF 100 Residential Eviction, Form 1 Summons, Form 2 Complaint, divorce/custody JDFs). Generate the signed PDF server-side on submit; keep the PDF as printable output, not the sole interface
- Complete tagging of the remaining Self-Help Forms library; establish an accessibility gate in the form-revision workflow so every new revision is tagged before publication
- Complete an authenticated-session audit of the e-filing portal: session timeout warnings, extend-session control, in-progress filing preservation
- Expand Spanish-language coverage of the forms library, or re-label the language toggle to match actual coverage
- Align the e-filing portal visual design and navigation with the parent site where feasible
- Consolidate footer social-media carousel with real <img alt> and accessible names on each link

Within 180 days (by October 20, 2026)

- Publish a public-facing WCAG 2.1 AA conformance VPAT/ACR for each major digital property
- Train web, content, and procurement staff on Title II requirements; update RFP and vendor contract templates to require WCAG 2.1 AA conformance (with VPAT submission)
- Establish a rolling external audit program: at least annually, by an outside firm with lived-experience testers (users of JAWS, NVDA, VoiceOver, Dragon NaturallySpeaking, switch devices)
- Publish the HB 24-1454 status report as HTML (with PDF alternative)
- Migrate from 'monthly manual and automated testing' language toward a specified testing protocol with published scope

Ongoing

- Accessibility-first design review for any new digital service; no launch without an accessibility signoff
- Every new PDF form tagged before publication; no exceptions; if tagging cannot be completed, the PDF is not published
- Accessibility feedback form response SLA (e.g., 5 business days for initial response, 30 days for remediation commitment)

Appendix A — WCAG 2.1 AA Success Criteria Referenced

The table below lists the WCAG 2.1 criteria cited in this audit, with a plain-language summary. The full normative text is available at w3.org/TR/WCAG21.

SC	Criterion	Level	Plain-language summary
1.1.1	Non-text Content	A	All images, icons, and other non-text content have text alternatives
1.2.2	Captions (Prerecorded)	A	Prerecorded video has synchronized captions
1.2.3	Audio Description or Media Alternative	A	Prerecorded video has audio description or transcript
1.2.5	Audio Description (Prerecorded)	AA	All prerecorded video has audio description
1.3.1	Info and Relationships	A	Structure (headings, lists, tables, form labels) is in the markup, not just visual
1.3.2	Meaningful Sequence	A	Reading order is preserved when CSS is off
2.1.1	Keyboard	A	All functionality is operable with keyboard alone
2.2.1	Timing Adjustable	A	Users can extend or disable time limits
2.2.6	Timeouts	AAA	Users warned about data loss from inactivity (cited as AAA-adjacent)
2.4.1	Bypass Blocks	A	Repeated content (navigation) can be skipped
2.4.2	Page Titled	A	Every page has a meaningful title
2.4.3	Focus Order	A	Focus moves in a meaningful sequence
2.4.4	Link Purpose (In Context)	A	Link text explains where the link goes
2.4.5	Multiple Ways	AA	More than one way to find any page
2.4.6	Headings and Labels	AA	Headings and form labels describe topic or purpose
2.4.9	Link Purpose (Link Only)	AAA	Link text explains where the link goes even out of context (cited as best practice)
3.1.1	Language of Page	A	The default language of the page is identified in markup

SC	Criterion	Level	Plain-language summary
3.1.2	Language of Parts	AA	Inline changes of language are identified in markup
3.1.5	Reading Level	AAA	Supplemental content for content above lower secondary reading level (cited as context)
3.2.3	Consistent Navigation	AA	Navigation is in the same relative order across pages
3.2.4	Consistent Identification	AA	Components with the same function are labeled consistently
3.2.5	Change on Request	AAA	Context changes happen only on user request (cited as best practice)
3.3.1	Error Identification	A	Input errors are identified in text
3.3.2	Labels or Instructions	A	Form inputs have labels or instructions
3.3.3	Error Suggestion	AA	Input errors are accompanied by suggestions
3.3.5	Help	AAA	Context-sensitive help available (cited as AAA-adjacent)
4.1.1	Parsing	A	Markup is well-formed (note: obsolete in WCAG 2.2, retained here for 2.1 AA)
4.1.2	Name, Role, Value	A	Interface components have accessible name, role, and programmatic state
4.1.3	Status Messages	AA	Status messages can be announced to assistive technology

Appendix B — Methodology and Limitations

What this audit covers

- Static HTML/DOM inspection of each listed URL (rendered server output as of April 20, 2026)
- Cross-reference against WCAG 2.1 Level A and AA success criteria
- Inspection of one representative PDF (Form 1 — County Civil Summons) at the content-stream level
- Regulatory cross-reference to 28 C.F.R. Part 35 Subpart H (ADA Title II web rule)

What this audit does NOT cover

- Interactive keyboard traversal testing — focus traps, tab order, modal escape
- Screen reader verification in JAWS, NVDA, VoiceOver, or TalkBack
- Voice-control testing with Dragon NaturallySpeaking or Voice Control
- Authenticated-session behavior (post-login e-filing workflows, session timeouts)
- Color-contrast sampling (requires visual rendering)
- Mobile-app audit of any Colorado Judicial Branch native applications
- User testing with people with disabilities
- Automated scanner cross-check (axe-core, WAVE, Lighthouse, Pa11y)

Implication

A full WCAG 2.1 AA conformance engagement — including runtime testing, automated scans, and user testing — will surface additional findings, particularly in the classes of focus management, dynamic content, and contrast. The Branch should treat this audit as the starting inventory, not the exhaustive list.

Appendix C — Regulatory References

- U.S. Department of Justice, 'Nondiscrimination on the Basis of Disability; Accessibility of Web Information and Services of State and Local Government Entities,' 89 Fed. Reg. 31320 (April 24, 2024). Codified at 28 C.F.R. Part 35, Subpart H
- Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG) 2.1, W3C Recommendation, June 5, 2018 (with June 21, 2023 errata)
- Colorado House Bill 24-1454 — State Agency Digital Accessibility
- Section 504 of the Rehabilitation Act of 1973, 29 U.S.C. § 794
- ADA.gov, 'State and Local Governments: First Steps Toward Complying with the ADA Title II Web and Mobile Application Accessibility Rule'
- U.S. Access Board, 'Section 508 Standards for Electronic and Information Technology' (cross-reference for federal procurement and for PDF accessibility guidance)

A note on exceptions

The DOJ rule contains limited exceptions: archived content, preexisting conventional electronic documents (PDF/Word/PowerPoint/Excel) that are not currently used to apply for or participate in a service, content posted by third parties, and individualized password-protected documents about a specific person. Of these, the preexisting-documents exception is the most commonly misapplied. The Self-Help Forms library does NOT qualify: the forms are currently used to apply for services (filing a case, requesting a protection order, seeking a fee waiver). They must conform to WCAG 2.1 AA. The forms-page library is the single largest exposure surface in this audit.

— End of report —